areas. It was heart-rending to see entire villages covered by a carpet of snow. The silhouettes of some of the houses were visible under the snow. We tried to look for people but found no signs of life in most places. Unfortunately for the terrorists, many of them perished as their hideouts in the hills and forests got totally snowed in. The people of Kashmir were very grateful and for once, the usually acerbic local media also showered praise on the army and the air force. We suddenly became angels! The central government stepped in and poured a lot of aid. Army relief teams spread out to the remotest corners of the Pir Panjal range and its valleys, which were the worst hit. Kashmir limped back to normalcy.

Later that year, on the morning of 8 October 2005, a severe earthquake caused tremendous loss of life and devastation in PoK and in some adjoining areas on our side of the LoC. This was the second disaster that struck the Kashmir region in the year. It was of an intensity of 7.6 on the Richter scale, enough to flatten out most of the capital town of Muzaffarabad in PoK and practically all the villages around it. It was about the same intensity as the earthquakes in Quetta (1935) or in Gujarat (2001) and this tragedy resulted in over 70,000 deaths and injuries to over one lakh people in PoK. On the Indian side, the worst-hit areas were Uri and Tangdhar along the LoC. There was colossal loss of property in the area, though not so much loss of life. Terrorist training camps in PoK were also hit. 'When entire villages have been wiped out, it is most likely that these terrorist camps (in Muzaffarabad area) have also been affected,' was my response to questions by the media.

'… a majority of the training camps were located near the epicentre of the quake with Lashkar's office and hospital in Muzaffarabad being completely razed to the ground. Harkat-ul-Mujahideen's training centre at Balakot and Batrasi, Jaish-e-Mohammed's camp at Attock, Al Badr's at Oghi, Lashkar's at Mansera and Hizbul's recruitment camp at Jungle-Mangal had been damaged to a great extent.'[1] Was it divine retribution in the case of these terrorists?

Once again, without waiting for a formal request for aid from the state government, we reached out to the calamity-struck people of